

Oblivious in Jaipur

Even a week after the blasts, the police are still groping in the dark

Nearly a week after the nine serial blasts which killed 67 persons in Jaipur, the Special Task Force is groping in the dark. The bombs were most likely 8 kg devices made of explosive ammonium nitrate and steel ball bearings. A group called the Indian Mujahideen released an e-mail 24 hours after the blast with a video of a stationary cycle. The e-mail, sent from a cybercafé in Sahibabad, spewed communal abuse and claimed that the attacks were aimed at the tourism sector. This may be a ploy to divert focus

force acts independently with little or no coordination with others, making it difficult to track terrorists across state borders. A suspect behind last year's Mecca Masjid blasts in Hyderabad was arrested by the BSF in West Bengal and confessed to having smuggled in 20 persons to operate sleeper cells in Jammu & Kashmir and Hyderabad. Though the Andhra Pradesh Police had been provided with inputs, it did not pursue it.

The main reason that states are resisting the Central agency is because they fear an invasion of their turf. "It will become a political tool to curtail the state governments' powers and interfere in its working in the name of containing terror," says Amit Shah, Gujarat's minister of state for home,

power to arrest or prosecute suspects and relies on state police, which have poor intelligence set-ups. Unlike the CBI, state police forces don't have the power to coordinate with Interpol for extraditing terror suspects. The CBI is the only Central body tasked with investigation but enters the scene only after a crime has already been committed and that too after a court directive or an express state government notification.

The Ministry of Home Affairs says it cannot implement the FIA without modifying the Constitution. However, former Uttar Pradesh DGP Prakash Singh has invoked Article 246 of the Constitution in a PIL in the Supreme Court, which puts 'defence of India' under the Union list for the creation of an FIA. In its September 2006 judgement on Singh's PIL, the Supreme Court asked the Centre to consult the NHRC, the Soli Sorabjee Committee on police reforms and the Bureau of Police Research and Development and the Union government before setting up the Central body. The first three have given the green-signal to FIA, but the Centre is still dragging its feet. The Ministry of Home Affairs was given four weeks to submit its views but has sought four extensions since September 2006 saying it is still "consulting" the states.

"Police and public order being state subjects under the Constitution, the Centre has its limitations," Home Minister Shivraj Patil said at a coordination meeting of the proposed FIA. Yet, the fate of agencies created after crises—the National Technical Research Organisation set up after the Kargil War and the Joint Intelligence Task Force after the 2006 Mumbai blasts—has led experts to question the creation of a new agency. "It will be sensible and economical to augment and empower an existing organisation like the IB than create a new one," says Ajai Sahni, Centre for Conflict Management. But with the blasts becoming hopelessly politicised and the Central government pursuing an elusive consensus, there is little hope of a central organisation taking off.

with Uday Mahurkar,

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from HUI. Investigations have established that the 10 bicycles were bought between 1 p.m. and 3 p.m. on the day of the blasts by 10 or more persons aged between 20 and 25 years. They carried backpacks and waited calmly at the shop for 20 minutes not fearing recognition, giving the police reason to believe they came from outside the city. The immediate fallout has been the exodus of illegal Bangladeshi immigrants who are leaving the city following a state government diktat. At least 2,500 families were identified for deportation in 2004 but only 400 have been sent back so far.

by Rohit Parihar

UNSOLVED: Police believe the bombers were not locals

who suggests the Central government should instead provide teeth to the states and tighten the intelligence set up. Both Gujarat and Rajasthan are already miffed with the Centre's attempts to deny them anti-terror legislation. The Rajasthan Control of Organised Crime bill has been pending since 2005 while the Gujarat Organised Crime Control Act (GUJOC) has been held up by the UPA Government since 2004.

Tracking terrorists is a responsibility scattered between a bewildering number of agencies. The Intelligence Bureau (IB), tasked with collecting intelligence on terrorists, lacks the